



Official website of the Department of Homeland Security

On July 17, 2026, DHS [published](#) a final rule establishing a fixed time academic students, J exchange visitors and representatives of foreign

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WORKING IN THE UNITED STATES

The U.S. government takes working illegally very seriously. This page will help you learn the basics of the work authorization process.

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There are limited work opportunities available in the United States for F-1 students. For this reason, before coming to the United States, F-1 students must prove they have the financial ability (e.g., present bank statements) to pay for tuition and living expenses while studying. If you decide that you want to work, the first step is always to talk with your [designated school official \(DSO\)](#).

If your DSO knows you are working without permission, they must report it through [SEVIS](#), meaning your SEVIS record will be terminated. That means that you will have to leave the United States immediately, and you may not be allowed to return.

Depending on [your status](#) and [program of study](#), you may be eligible for the following type of employment opportunities while you study in the United States:

On-Campus

Off-Campus

Off-campus employment is work that takes place outside of a school campus. Off-campus employment is only available to F-1 students who have completed at least one full academic year of their program of study, and who have an economic hardship that qualifies for the [Department of Homeland](#)

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To apply for off-campus employment, you must explain your economic hardship situation and receive approval to work from your DSO. If your DSO determines that the situation applies, he or she will recommend you and give you an updated [Form I-20](#), [“Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Status.”](#)

Once you have the new Form I-20, you must file a [Form I-765, “Application for Employment Authorization,”](#) with [USCIS](#) within 30 days of receiving your recommendation.

If USCIS approves you to work, they will send you a [Form I-766, “Employment Authorization Document,” \(EAD\)](#) with the dates that you may work off-campus.

Please note that you cannot begin to work while the Form I-765 is pending with USCIS. As with on-campus employment, you must also [apply for a SSN](#). Please see the [F-1 Student Off-Campus resource page on ICE.gov](#) for additional information.

For more information about training opportunities for international students visit our [Training page](#).

Related Tags: [Employment](#)

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